

RSE Survey - 2016

The purpose of this survey is to collect information about *Research Software Engineers* (RSEs). These are the people who work in research groups, or work with researchers, to produce the software that is used in research. You have received this link because you were identified as a member of the UK RSE Association or as someone working in an RSE role.

There is currently little reliable information about the size or the health of the RSE community, so we have been asked to collect this information to help funders and other research organisations to develop policies that will support the RSE community. This questionnaire gives you the opportunity to express your views about your current job and give us information about your career path. Your information will help us evaluate the RSE community and understand how the community can be supported and better represented. This survey is the first in what will become an annual event. The longitudinal data we capture will help plot the evolution of the community.

Please note that this research is not compulsory and even if you decide to participate you can withdraw at any moment, the survey is entirely anonymous and we don't collect or store any identifiable information.

This study is conducted by the [Software Sustainability Institute](#) and the investigators are [Simon Hettrick](#) and [Olivier Philippe](#). The survey is hosted at University of Southampton and respects the provisions of the [Data Protection Act](#). These records are anonymised and access is strictly protected and granted for the main researchers only. The purpose of the data is for research only and the data will not be shared with third-parties.

If you would like more information about the research or about the data collection, please contact [Olivier Philippe](#).

In the case of concern or complaint, please contact [Simon Hettrick](#).

Section 1. A few questions about yourself

Question 1.1

In which country do you live?

☐	United Kingdom
☐	Virgin Islands (British)
☐	United States

☐	Afghanistan
☐	Albania
☐	Algeria
☐	American Samoa
☐	Andorra
☐	Angola
☐	Anguilla
☐	Antarctica
☐	Antigua And Barbuda
☐	Argentina
☐	Armenia
☐	Aruba
☐	Australia
☐	Austria
☐	Azerbaijan
☐	Bahamas
☐	Bahrain
☐	Bangladesh
☐	Barbados

☐	Belarus
☐	Belgium
☐	Belize
☐	Benin
☐	Bermuda
☐	Bhutan
☐	Bolivia
☐	Bosnia And Herzegovina
☐	Botswana
☐	Bouvet Island
☐	Brazil
☐	British Indian Ocean Territory
☐	Brunei
☐	Bulgaria
☐	Burkina Faso
☐	Burundi
☐	Cambodia
☐	Cameroon
☐	Canada

☐	Cape Verde
☐	Cayman Islands
☐	Central African Republic
☐	Chad
☐	Chile
☐	China
☐	Christmas Island
☐	Cocos (Keeling) Islands
☐	Colombia
☐	Comoros
☐	Congo
☐	Cook Islands
☐	Costa Rica
☐	Cote D'Ivoire (Ivory Coast)
☐	Croatia (Hrvatska)
☐	Cuba
☐	Cyprus
☐	Czech Republic
☐	Democratic Republic Of Congo (Zaire)

☐	Denmark
☐	Djibouti
☐	Dominica
☐	Dominican Republic
☐	East Timor
☐	Ecuador
☐	Egypt
☐	El Salvador
☐	Equatorial Guinea
☐	Eritrea
☐	Estonia
☐	Ethiopia
☐	Falkland Islands (Malvinas)
☐	Faroe Islands
☐	Fiji
☐	Finland
☐	France
☐	France, Metropolitan
☐	French Guinea

☐	French Polynesia
☐	French Southern Territories
☐	Gabon
☐	Gambia
☐	Georgia
☐	Germany
☐	Ghana
☐	Gibraltar
☐	Greece
☐	Greenland
☐	Grenada
☐	Guadeloupe
☐	Guam
☐	Guatemala
☐	Guinea
☐	Guinea-Bissau
☐	Guyana
☐	Haiti
☐	Heard And McDonald Islands

☐	Honduras
☐	Hong Kong
☐	Hungary
☐	Iceland
☐	India
☐	Indonesia
☐	Iran
☐	Iraq
☐	Ireland
☐	Israel
☐	Italy
☐	Jamaica
☐	Japan
☐	Jordan
☐	Kazakhstan
☐	Kenya
☐	Kiribati
☐	Kuwait
☐	Kyrgyzstan

☐	Laos
☐	Latvia
☐	Lebanon
☐	Lesotho
☐	Liberia
☐	Libya
☐	Liechtenstein
☐	Lithuania
☐	Luxembourg
☐	Macau
☐	Macedonia
☐	Madagascar
☐	Malawi
☐	Malaysia
☐	Maldives
☐	Mali
☐	Malta
☐	Marshall Islands
☐	Martinique

☐	Mauritania
☐	Mauritius
☐	Mayotte
☐	Mexico
☐	Micronesia
☐	Moldova
☐	Monaco
☐	Mongolia
☐	Montserrat
☐	Morocco
☐	Mozambique
☐	Myanmar (Burma)
☐	Namibia
☐	Nauru
☐	Nepal
☐	Netherlands
☐	Netherlands Antilles
☐	New Caledonia
☐	New Zealand

☐	Nicaragua
☐	Niger
☐	Nigeria
☐	Niue
☐	Norfolk Island
☐	North Korea
☐	Northern Mariana Islands
☐	Norway
☐	Oman
☐	Pakistan
☐	Palau
☐	Panama
☐	Papua New Guinea
☐	Paraguay
☐	Peru
☐	Philippines
☐	Pitcairn
☐	Poland
☐	Portugal

☐	Puerto Rico
☐	Qatar
☐	Reunion
☐	Romania
☐	Russia
☐	Rwanda
☐	Saint Helena
☐	Saint Kitts And Nevis
☐	Saint Lucia
☐	Saint Pierre And Miquelon
☐	Saint Vincent And The Grenadines
☐	San Marino
☐	Sao Tome And Principe
☐	Saudi Arabia
☐	Senegal
☐	Seychelles
☐	Sierra Leone
☐	Singapore
☐	Slovak Republic

☐	Slovenia
☐	Solomon Islands
☐	Somalia
☐	South Africa
☐	South Georgia And South Sandwich Islands
☐	South Korea
☐	Spain
☐	Sri Lanka
☐	Sudan
☐	Suriname
☐	Svalbard And Jan Mayen
☐	Swaziland
☐	Sweden
☐	Switzerland
☐	Syria
☐	Taiwan
☐	Tajikistan
☐	Tanzania
☐	Thailand

☐	Togo
☐	Tokelau
☐	Tonga
☐	Trinidad And Tobago
☐	Tunisia
☐	Turkey
☐	Turkmenistan
☐	Turks And Caicos Islands
☐	Tuvalu
☐	Uganda
☐	Ukraine
☐	United Arab Emirates
☐	United States Minor Outlying Islands
☐	Uruguay
☐	Uzbekistan
☐	Vanuatu
☐	Vatican City (Holy See)
☐	Venezuela
☐	Vietnam

☐	Virgin Islands (US)
☐	Wallis And Futuna Islands
☐	Western Sahara
☐	Western Samoa
☐	Yemen
☐	Yugoslavia
☐	Zambia
☐	Zimbabwe

Question 1.2

What is the highest qualification you have obtained?

☐	GCSEs
☐	Further Education (NVQ A-Level ...)
☐	Undergraduate degree
☐	Masters degree
☐	Doctorate
☐	None
☐	Other

Question 1.2b

What was your academic subject?

☐	Architecture Building and Planning
☐	Biological Sciences

☐	Combined studies
☐	Computer Sciences
☐	Creative Arts and Design
☐	Medicine and Dentistry
☐	Subjects allied to Medicine
☐	Veterinary Sciences Agriculture and related subjects
☐	Physical Sciences
☐	Mathematical and Computer Sciences
☐	Engineering
☐	Technologies
☐	Social studies
☐	Law
☐	Business and Administrative studies
☐	Mass Communications and Documentation
☐	Linguistics Classics and related subjects
☐	European Languages Literature and related subjects
☐	Eastern Asiatic African American and Australasian Languages Literature and related subjects
☐	Historical and Philosophical studies
☐	Education

☐	Other
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Question 1.3

Do you hold any professional qualifications? If yes, please enter them separated by commas.

Question 1.4

This survey is primarily intended for Research Software Engineers. The following questions help us understand how well you match the definition of a Research Software Engineer as defined by the UK RSE Association <http://www.rse.ac.uk/who.html>

Are you employed primarily to develop software for research?	☐	☐	☐
Do you spend more time developing software than conducting research?	☐	☐	☐
Are you employed as a postdoctoral researcher?	☐	☐	☐
Are you the person who "does computers" in your research group?	☐	☐	☐

Section 2. Employment history

Question 2.1

Do you work for a university?

☐	Yes
☐	No

Question 2.1b

Which university?

☐	University of Aberdeen
☐	Abertay University
☐	Aberystwyth University
☐	Anglia Ruskin University
☐	The Arts University Bournemouth

☐	University of the Arts London
☐	Aston University
☐	Bangor University
☐	University of Bath
☐	Bath Spa University
☐	University of Bedfordshire
☐	University of Birmingham
☐	Birmingham City University
☐	University College Birmingham
☐	Bishop Grosseteste University
☐	University Centre at Blackburn College
☐	University of Bolton
☐	Bournemouth University
☐	BPP University
☐	University of Bradford
☐	University of Brighton
☐	University of Bristol
☐	Brunel University
☐	University of Buckingham

☐	Buckinghamshire New University
☐	University of Cambridge
☐	Canterbury Christ Church University
☐	Cardiff University
☐	Cardiff Metropolitan University (UWIC)
☐	University of Central Lancashire
☐	University of Chester
☐	University of Chichester
☐	City University
☐	Coventry University
☐	Cranfield University
☐	University for the Creative Arts
☐	University of Cumbria
☐	De Montfort University
☐	University of Derby
☐	University of Dundee
☐	Durham University
☐	University of East Anglia
☐	University of East London

☐	Edge Hill University
☐	University of Edinburgh
☐	Edinburgh Napier University
☐	University of Essex
☐	University of Exeter
☐	Falmouth University
☐	University of Glasgow
☐	Glasgow Caledonian University
☐	University of Gloucestershire
☐	University of Greenwich
☐	Glyndŵr University
☐	Harper Adams University
☐	Heriot-Watt University
☐	University of Hertfordshire
☐	University of the Highlands & Islands
☐	University of Huddersfield
☐	University of Hull
☐	Imperial College London
☐	Keele University

☐	University of Kent
☐	Kingston University
☐	Lancaster University
☐	University of Law
☐	University of Leeds
☐	Leeds Beckett University
☐	Leeds Trinity University
☐	University of Leicester
☐	University of Lincoln
☐	University of Liverpool
☐	Liverpool Hope University
☐	Liverpool John Moores University
☐	University of London
☐	London Metropolitan University
☐	London South Bank University
☐	Loughborough University
☐	University of Manchester
☐	Manchester Metropolitan University
☐	Middlesex University

☐	Newcastle University
☐	Newman University
☐	University of Northampton
☐	Northumbria University
☐	Norwich University of the Arts
☐	University of Nottingham
☐	Nottingham Trent University
☐	The Open University
☐	University of Oxford
☐	Oxford Brookes University
☐	University of Plymouth
☐	University of Portsmouth
☐	Queen's University Belfast
☐	University of Reading
☐	Regent's University London
☐	The Robert Gordon University
☐	Roehampton University
☐	Royal Agricultural University
☐	Royal College of Art

☐	University of St Andrews
☐	University of St Mark & St John
☐	St Mary's University
☐	University of Salford
☐	University of Sheffield
☐	Sheffield Hallam University
☐	University of Southampton
☐	Southampton Solent University
☐	University of South Wales
☐	Staffordshire University
☐	University of Stirling
☐	University of Strathclyde
☐	University of Sunderland
☐	University of Surrey
☐	University of Sussex
☐	Swansea University
☐	Teesside University
☐	Ulster University
☐	University of Wales

☐	University of Warwick
☐	University of West London
☐	University of Westminster
☐	University of the West of England
☐	University of the West of Scotland
☐	University of Winchester
☐	University of Wolverhampton
☐	University of Worcester
☐	University of York
☐	York St John University
☐	Other/Not listed

Question 2.1c

Which organisation do you work for?

Question 2.2

What is your official job title (i.e. the job title on your contract of employment)?

Question 2.3

In what year did you start your current position?

Question 2.4

What type of contract are you employed on?

☐	Permanent
☐	Fixed term
☐	Agency staff

☐	Freelancer consultant contractors
☐	Zero hour contract

Question 2.4b

What is the duration of your current contract?

Month	
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Question 2.5

Do you work full time or part time?

☐	Full time
☐	Part time

Question 2.6

Is this your first job?

☐	Yes
☐	No

Question 2.6b

Have you previously worked in the private sector?

☐	Yes
☐	No

Question 2.6c

What was the official job title of your previous job (i.e. the job title stated on your contact of employment)?

Question 2.6d

What was the type of your contract?

☐	Permanent
☐	Fixed-term

☐	Agency Staff
☐	Freelancer consultant contractors
☐	Zero hour contract

Section 3. Current position

Question 3.1

Are you known in your group by a different job title (e.g. the job title on your group website or business cards)?

☐	Yes
☐	No

Question 3.1b

What is this job title?

Question 3.2

Do you work within a group that provides software development help or expertise to researchers from other groups within your organisation?

☐	Yes
☐	No

Question 3.3

What percentage of your time do you spend developing software each week?

Question 3.4

Has your software ever contributed to research that has been published in a journal or at a conference?

☐	Yes
☐	No

Question 3.4b

Were you acknowledged in the paper?	☐	☐
Were you named as a co-author of the paper?	☐	☐

Were you named as the lead author of the paper?

☐ ☐

Question 3.5

What is the bus factor of your most important software project?

Your "most important software project" is the work-related project that you believe to have had the greatest impact on the research community.

The "bus factor" designates the minimal number of developers that have to be hit by a bus (or quit) before a project is incapacitated.

1	2	3	4	5	+5
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Question 3.6

Is there a technical hand-over plan for your most important software project?

Your "most important software project" is the work-related project that you believe to have had the greatest impact on the research community.

☐	Yes
☐	No

Section 4. Your perceptions about your current position

This section asks questions about your feelings toward your current job. Please note that there are no good or bad answers. Please try to answer as more honestly as possible.

These answers will not be shared with anyone and there is no way for us to personally identify you.

Question 4.1

Do you receive sufficient information on the results of your work?	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Does your work give you the opportunity to check on how well you are doing your work?	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
In your work, do you have access to sufficient data and information?	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
How often do you feel frustrated when not given the opportunity to achieve your personal work-related goals?	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
How often do you look forward to another day at work?	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Question 4.2

I feel fairly well satisfied with my job	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
It would not be very difficult for me to get an equivalent job in a different organisation	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I am satisfied with a word of thanks from my supervisor/line manager	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
It is likely that my next position will be an RSE role	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I can think of a number of organisations that would probably offer me a job	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
My experience is in demand on the labour market	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I find real enjoyment in my job	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Most days I am enthusiastic about my job	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I am satisfied with my supervisor/line manager's confidence in me	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
My current position is an integral part of my career plan	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Section 5. Your perceptions about your current position 2

This section asks questions about your feelings toward your current job. Please note that there are no good or bad answers. Please try to answer as more honestly as possible.

These answers will not be shared with anyone and there is no way for us to personally identify you.

Question 5.1

I like my job better than the average person	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
The process I have to complete to gain a promotion is clear and understandable	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
There are many opportunities within my chosen career plan	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Given my qualifications and experience, getting a new job would not be very hard at all	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I am satisfied with the recognition I receive from my supervisor/line manager for doing my job	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

It is likely that I will gain a promotion within my current group	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I am satisfied with the compliments from my supervisor/line manager concerning my work	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
My current job satisfies my personal needs	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I would accept another job at the same compensation level if I was offered it	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
I am satisfied with the encouragement from my supervisor/line manager while doing my job	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Question 5.2

Do you receive sufficient information on the purpose of your work?	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Does your work provide you with direct feedback on how well you are doing your work?	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Does your supervisor/line manager inform you about how well you are doing your work?	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Do your colleagues inform you about how well you are doing your work?	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
How often do you consider leaving your job?	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
How often do dream about getting another job that will better suit your needs?	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Section 6. Some final questions

This section asks about your socio-demographic information. It helps us to know who are the people within the RSE community. These answers will not be shared with anyone and there is no way for us to personally identify you.

Question 6.1

In your opinion, what are the three most important skills that a Research Software Engineer must possess?

Skill 1	
Skill 2	

Skill 3	
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Question 6.2

Are you a member of the UK RSE Association? (Members are people who have signed up to the UK RSE mailing list)

☐	Yes
☐	No

Question 6.3

What three skills would you like to acquire or improve to help your work as a Research Software Engineer? The skills can be technical and non-technical.

Skill 1	
Skill 2	
Skill 3	

Question 6.4

What are the three tools or services you use most often to achieve your work?

Tool/Service 1	
Tool/Service 2	
Tool/Service 3	

Question 6.5

Please select your gender

☐	Female
☐	Male

☐	Other
☐	Prefer not to answer

Question 6.6

Please select your age

☐	18 to 24 years
☐	25 to 34 years
☐	35 to 44 years
☐	45 to 54 years
☐	55 to 64 years
☐	Age 65 or older

Question 6.7

Please select the range of your salary

☐	Less than £25 000
☐	£25 000 to £29 999
☐	£30 000 to £34 999
☐	£35 000 to £39 999
☐	£40 000 to £44 999
☐	£45 000 to £50 000
☐	£50 000 to £59 999
☐	£60 000 to £69 999
☐	£70 000 to £99 000

☐	£100 000 or more
☐	Prefer not to say
☐	

Question 6.8

What is your Operating System of choice for use at work?

☐	GNU/Linux
☐	OS X
☐	Windows
☐	Other

Section 7. Thank you very much

Thank you very much for your participation. If you are interested in the outcomes of this survey, you can leave your email address and we will contact you once a report is available. Alternatively you can join the [UK RSE Association](#) or look out for updates on [Twitter](#).

Question 7.1

I would like to leave my email address so that I can receive a report on the outcomes of this survey.

☐	Yes
☐	No

Question 7.1b

Please enter your email address

Thank you very much!